Tenses

The big idea

Tense shows the **time of an action**: present, past or future. Each time has four **aspects**: simple, continuous, perfect and perfect continuous. That gives **12 tense forms**. CBSE tests tenses through gap-filling, editing, transformation and especially in **story and diary writing**, where you must keep tenses consistent.

The 12 tense forms (verb: write)

	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect continuous
Present	I write / He writes	I am writing	I have written	I have been writing
Past	I wrote	I was writing	I had written	I had been writing
Future	I will write	I will be writing	I will have written	I will have been writing

Present tenses

- **Simple present**: habits, facts, universal truths, timetables. The sun **rises** in the east. The train **leaves** at 6 p.m. Signal words: always, usually, every day.
- **Present continuous**: actions happening now or planned for the near future. She **is reading** now. We **are leaving** tomorrow.
- **Present perfect**: past action with a link to the present; the time is not stated. I **have finished** my homework. Signal words: just, already, yet, ever, never, since, for.

- **Present perfect continuous**: action that began in the past and is still going on. It **has been raining** since morning.

PRESENT PERFECT WITH A PAST TIME

"I have seen him yesterday" is wrong. With a definite past time (yesterday, last week, in 2020), use simple past: I **saw** him yesterday.

Past tenses

- **Simple past**: completed action at a definite past time. Kalam **sold** tamarind seeds in 1939.
- **Past continuous**: action in progress in the past, often interrupted. I **was sleeping** when the phone **rang**.
- **Past perfect**: the earlier of two past actions. The train **had left** before we **reached** the station.
- **Past perfect continuous**: action going on for some time before another past action. She **had been waiting** for two hours when he arrived.

Future tenses

- **Simple future**: will/shall + base verb. I **will help** you.
- **Future continuous**: action in progress at a future time. At 8 p.m. tomorrow I **will be travelling**.
- **Future perfect**: action completed before a future time. By June, they **will have finished** the bridge.
- **Future perfect continuous**: duration up to a future time. By next year, he **will have been working** here for ten years.
- Other ways to show the future: **be going to** (plans/predictions), present continuous (fixed arrangements), simple present (timetables).

SINCE VS FOR

Since + point of time (since Monday, since 2015). For + period of time (for three days, for two hours).

CONDITIONAL SENTENCES

If + simple present → will + verb: If it **rains**, we **will stay** home. Do not write "If it will rain".

TENSE CONSISTENCY IN WRITING

Stories and diary entries are usually in the **past tense**; descriptions of places and articles often in the **present**. Do not switch tenses without reason. Examiners deduct marks for "He went to the market and buys vegetables".

Practice

Fill in the blanks: (a) Water ___ (boil) at 100 °C. (b) When I reached the stop, the bus ___ (leave). (c) She ___ (live) in Delhi since 2018. (d) Look! The children ___ (play) in the rain. (e) This time tomorrow, we ___ (fly) to Kathmandu.
Answers: (a) boils (b) had left (c) has been living / has lived (d) are playing (e) will be flying

Quick recap

- 3 times × 4 aspects = 12 tenses.
- Present perfect: no definite past time; since = point, for = period.
- Past perfect = earlier of two past actions.
- Keep tenses consistent in writing.

Practice questions

1. The earth ___ round the sun.
   (a) moved (b) is moved (c) moves (d) has moving
2. I ___ this film last Sunday.
   (a) have seen (b) saw (c) had been seeing (d) have been seeing
3. She ___ in this school since 2019.
   (a) studies (b) studied (c) is studying (d) has been studying
4. When we reached the cinema, the film ___.
   (a) had already started (b) has already started (c) already starts (d) will start
5. I was having dinner when the lights ___.
   (a) go out (b) had been going out (c) went out (d) were going out
6. If it ___ tomorrow, the match will be cancelled.
   (a) will rain (b) rained (c) would rain (d) rains
7. By next March, they ___ the new library.
   (a) complete (b) will be complete (c) will have completed (d) have completed
8. Complete the paragraph with the correct forms of the verbs in brackets: Yesterday Margie (a) ___ (find) an old book. She (b) ___ (never see) a real book before. While she (c) ___ (read) it, her mother called her.

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. d 4. a 5. c 6. d 7. c 8. see notes